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GUESS ICONIC

THE NEW FRAGRANCES

My own backyard adventures have been less chaotic: trips to the garden store with a budget and a palette in mind, sketches and lists with staggered bloom cycles considered. But every book I've read or class I've taken has elicited both a sense of encouragement and intimidation regarding the vast array of knowledge still beyond my reach. There are parts of gardening that can feel intuitive (water when dry) and parts that feel almost paradoxical. It took a firm rosarian at the Brooklyn Botanic Garden to persuade me to hack my rose vines down to spindly shin-level spears, denuded of crisscrossing branches. "Trust me," she said, "they're going to love it."

So there was something undeniably appealing about throwing caution to the wind. A neighbor friend has a field of echinacea flowers in her front yard that by mid-summer looks like hundreds of emojis have popped up to flank her stoop, drunk-seeming bumblebees buzzing between them. She had read all the Piet Oudolf books, she told me, but when it came time to plant, she just tossed handfuls of seeds in the air. Could I transform a bare little corner of my backyard with the same spirit of abandon?

At the gardening store I bought packets of blackberry lily, cardinal climber, lobelia, aster, echinacea, lavender, and thyme seeds. At the last minute I added a packet of outhouse hollyhock, a plant so deemed because it has been known to grow tall and dense enough that it can create a screen for outdoor facilities. No privy in my backyard, but the bulky plastic compost wheel could use some camouflage. How did this selection rank according to my typical measures? Were these native? Not really, it turned out when I googled them later. Invasive? Oops, maybe a little, in some cases. I had planned to divide the plot—one half sown spontaneously, the other benefiting from more attention paid to spacing—but my own four-year-old daughter seemed to sense that approach was not in keeping with the spirit of the endeavor and proceeded to scatter at will. At the last minute I remembered that Ffern, the delectable organic fragrance company, had sent me a packet of cornflower, lady's bedstraw, and red campion with its newest, very pleasing seasonal scent, so I threw that in too. About 27 seconds later we were done. We gently trod on the soil, gave it a spray of water, and walked away.

There are, of course, complications that one doesn't need to venture too far into this trend to discover. The question of density, for starters—a lot of the videos involve flung fistfuls, the way an enthusiastic chef might salt a pot of water for pasta. More is more! Then you read the fine print on a packet of thyme seeds, each smaller than a poppy seed, and find out it is meant to cover up to 233 square feet. Assuming these plants sprout, you're supposed to thin them—a nice way of saying "kill your darlings"—if they are denser than a few inches apart. "It feels like infanticide," says noted gardener Jo Thompson, author of *The New Romantic Garden* (2025), when I call her for advice. Thompson's style has always been somewhat akin to chaos gardening—a bit unruly, a bit disordered, and more welcoming because of it. "I liked the idea that it was not all about me," she says. "I wanted to guide the garden and invite a sense of spontaneity." She likes plants that "look after themselves," she adds. Let nature take its course with minimal intervention.

There is ancient wisdom to the idea of cultivating plant diversity—the "three sister" crops (corn, beans, and squash) have long been grown in proximity to maximize yields. In fact, the term *chaos garden* has been traced back to farmer and writer Gabe Brown, author of *Dirt to Soil* (2018), who describes a regenerative experiment that began almost as a dare: He took a total of 70 species (including cover crops like cowpeas and soybeans, as well as vegetables and flowers) and spread them over a 30-acre field. Even though the conditions were not optimal that year, the process generated a thriving kitchen garden for him and his wife. "Shelly would send me to pick a vegetable for supper and whatever I tripped over was what I would bring home," Brown writes. Thompson, in her own garden, has been growing salvia near her roses—an approach that utilizes the natural fungicidal properties of salvia's leaves.

PURE ABANDON

A stairway at Gravetye Manor in England, a century-old garden that is considered a precursor to the modern, naturalistic aesthetic.

We know that plant diversity creates not only a more productive environment but a more stable and pollinator-friendly one. Having a variety of plants might help you prevent weeds and offer some natural pest protection. And this is an important consideration for even the most amateur backyard gardener: Recent research has shown that diversity-encouraging interventions in smaller-scale gardens had a disproportionately greater effect than in larger-scale gardens. "I don't like the term *chaos gardening*," the ecologist Douglas Tallamy tells me—he feels that it implies visions of unruliness. But he stresses the responsibility that anyone with even a tiny plot of earth should feel. "If people have a little garden that's a few square feet and the rest of it is a giant lawn," he says, "they're not doing anything with it." He points out that there are about 40 million acres of lawn in America—an area roughly the size of Washington State. If chaos gardening gets people accustomed to the idea of doing more than ceding their property to a landscaping company, then the benefits might go beyond a feel-good social media movement.

Within a week, my daughter came running to tell me that a shoot had emerged on my bare patch of Brooklyn dirt. It was a bit too soon for any of the seeds we had planted to sprout, but something had apparently drifted over and gotten a head start. I pulled out my plant identification app, but the leaves were tiny; it was too early to figure out what had taken root. The first resident of our chaos garden was a surprise, it seemed—what a delight indeed. □

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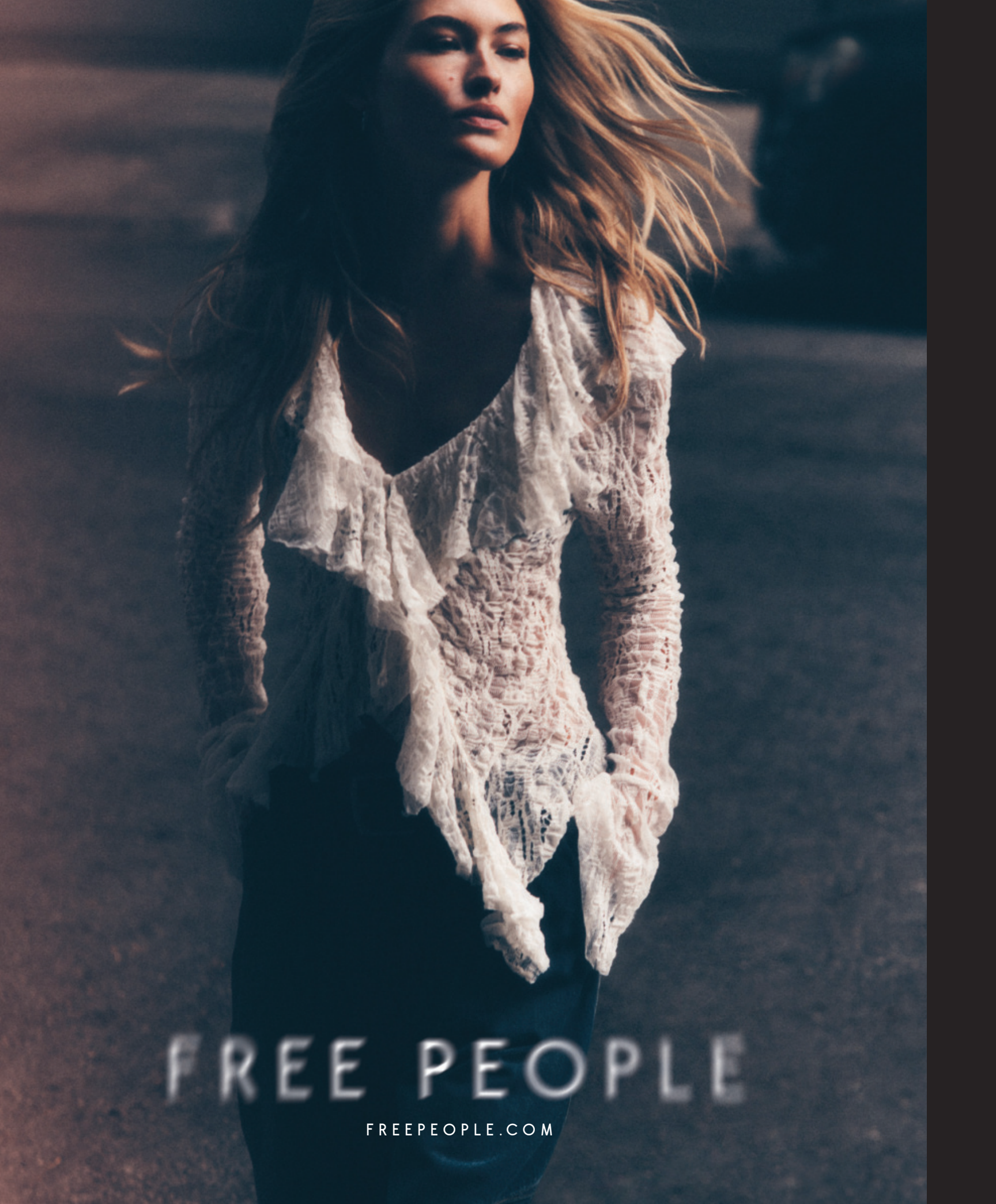
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COMFORTABLY NUMB

Can we improve our mood by freezing our faces? Maya Singer explores the new frontiers of the mind-body connection.

I was feeling bad, so I decided to get Botox. To be clear, I wasn't feeling bad about my face. Life in general was getting me down. I was weary, exhausted by the effort of ignoring the worrisome thoughts pinging around my head. I felt futile. I was beset by ambient dread. Thus, Botox. One sleepless night, I'd tumbled down an internet rabbit hole, reemerging with a handful of studies with byzantine titles like "Botulinum Toxin Therapy for Psychiatric Disorders in Clinical Practice: A Retrospective Case Study," suggesting Botox as a treatment for depression. The reason for this was hilariously straightforward: Botox—or any neuromodulator—inhibits frowning. That's it. That's the whole deal. It seemed worth trying.

Off I went to Weiser Skin MD in SoHo. I could have gotten a jab from one of the walk-in clinics popping up all over town—injection, the new mani-pedi!—but, as this was a matter of mental health, it seemed prudent to seek out a prestigious medical professional. Depression and anxiety "are serious conditions best managed by psychiatrists and/or psychologists," cautioned Jessica Weiser, MD, a board-certified dermatologist and Weiser Skin's founder and medical director. But, she added: "Patients do note that they feel more confident and relaxed after treatment." I asked the gracious Alessandra Haskin, MD, to aim for the "high end of minimal" as she prepared a needle for the muscles that lower the corners of the mouth. That was for good measure. The locus of scientific interest is the glabella, the region between the eyebrows where frown lines appear. I'd have to wait two weeks to witness the treatment's full effect.

As I waited, I asked myself: Do I feel more confident? Do I feel more relaxed? People kept telling me how great I looked; that was uplifting. I also wondered if I was turning into a psychopath. Perhaps you've seen the meme: A client, sitting in a doctor's office, points to his or her glabella: "Just go for the empathy part," says the Botoxee. "Of course, it's our bestseller," replies the injector. A little one-scene comedy responding to research suggesting that Botox curtails a person's capacity to "experience" the inner life of another.

The data on this is intriguing. One much-cited 2011 study showed that "emotion perception was significantly impaired" by Botox. In another, from 2023, researchers scanned women's brains pre- and post-Botox and found that suppressing the glabellar region could affect "the processing of emotional faces." This is a narrow sampling of the research; there are "several well-documented effects," according to Fernando Marmolejo-Ramos, PhD, an experimental psychologist based at Flinders University in Australia. Botox has been shown to inhibit emotional apprehension, Marmolejo-Ramos explains; Botoxees are "missing the subtext."

The scientific logic comes down to one essential: Our expressions both convey and sway our emotions. "Think of your face as a two-way street," Marmolejo-Ramos says. Emotion flows from brain to face, but there's also a "return signal," he elaborates, "and this bodily feedback helps us actually feel emotions." I frown because I'm sad—but it's also the reflex to frown that tells me I'm sad. Botox, immobilizing facial muscles, frustrates this signaling back and forth. >218

FROWN UPSIDE-DOWN
Some research posits that inhibiting our ability to knit our brow can have spirit-boosting effects.

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The result is a flattening of affect or "a subtle but measurable blunting of how the person processes, experiences, and reads emotion."

In the 1990s, the discovery of "mirror neurons" underlined that we subconsciously mimic each other, down to our tiniest facial expressions. These micro-expressions often escape cognition and are processed solely through simulation. So it follows that the more frozen your face, the less likely you are to clock that someone is anxious or lying to you or quietly amused. And if you're too frozen to take someone fully in, wouldn't it be harder for anyone to empathize with you?

"Go for the empathy part." A strange joke, if you think about it. But what makes the joke land is its kernel of sincerity, the idea that life might be easier, more frictionless, if we weren't troubled by the feelings of others. We live in an age of self-optimization; is lack of empathy somehow optimal? Does a cruel world require a cold heart and a frozen face?

"It's fascinating—it seems like a concerted effort to appear airbrushed," muses 36 North Moore Dermatology founder Evan Rieder, MD, of the intervention-forward, avatar-like aesthetic common on social media. "But I do not believe it's the result of a conscious attempt to achieve emotional blunting," he adds. Rieder, who is board-certified in both dermatology and psychiatry, is skeptical of the research—sure, *something* is happening at a psychological or emotional level when we get Botoxed, but not to a degree that would make a difference in the average person's life. "It's been sensationalized," he says.

And the jury is still out—way out—on Botox's efficacy as a mood-booster. "We looked closely at all the evidence and didn't find it compelling," says Jeff Larsen, professor of psychology and neuroscience at University of Tennessee and the coauthor of a 2021 meta-analysis of studies about Botox's effect on depression. Sample sizes were small; results were frequently improbable. "When it comes to momentary feelings, 10 seconds, maybe up to a minute, facial expression [for example, smiling] can have a *little* effect on how I'm feeling," Larsen says. As far as Botox improving my mood, "you're better off looking at cute puppy videos on YouTube."

This effect, too, is fleeting. I cued "30 Minutes of the World's CUTEST Puppies!" Half an hour later, my mood was about the same. But I did not, could not, frown. This had no perceptible impact on my cheeriness. The boost I got from Botox was that I liked my face a bit better, a result I'd have anticipated without reading umpteen scientific reports. That's not nothing, but as I said up top, my face was never the problem.

"Think of your face as a two-way street," psychologist Fernando Marmolejo-Ramos says. Emotion flows from brain to face, but there's also a "return signal"

The sense of constant crisis in the news and the developments in AI that are guiding us, rapidly, into terra incognita can make it difficult to see over any horizon beyond next week. And despair, it's been said, comes of the inability to conceive or construct a future. Hence: ambient dread. For me, at least. But philosophers have long had an antidote for this state of mind: the cocreation of a future by means of a hyperfocus on the present, doing the human stuff no AI will ever be able to do—sharing joy, giving someone a hug. Empathy, in other words. ChatGPT can't help my elderly neighbor carry her groceries up the stairs. It's a small thing, but more effective than Botox in quieting my mind and lightening my mood. *Care.* That's it. That's the whole deal. It seems worth trying. □

TINA CHARAD STUDIO.

BREAKING THE MOLD

Hollywood designer Tina Charad goes analog with ceramics.

Tina Charad first knew she wanted to work in film when she saw Baz Luhrmann's *Romeo + Juliet*. "I was blown away," she recalls. "The visual tapestry—it was just so rich." Several decades into a career as a graphic designer for film and television, she has conjured everything from the Technicolor grit of 1969 Los Angeles for Quentin Tarantino's *Once Upon a Time…in Hollywood* to modern interiors for Nancy Meyers. The job requires deep research, rigor, and skill—and, ideally, all this effort goes unnoticed.

Charad, 51, says that she has long had a perfectionist streak. But these days she's fighting that instinct, creating bowls, plates, vases, and other vessels that reflect a looser aesthetic. Her usual digital precision has no place here: "I took up ceramics to get off the computer," she says. She counts the artists Jennifer Rochlin, Hylton Nel, and Daisy Makeig-Jones (a 20th-century pottery designer for Wedgwood) among her influences. And, aesthetically, more is more. "I've never met a pattern I didn't love." A selection of her wares is sold at Pierce & Ward, the Los Angeles design studio known for modern heirlooms, and in 2027 she will have an exhibition at Knysna Fine Art in Knysna, South Africa.

Incorporating lines of text—akin to little poems—Charad aims to craft a humorous record of the present on the surface of her work. "The ceramic is the vehicle to tell this absurd little story," she says. And there is suspense in ceramics, just as in film: "Is this going to not break? Is this going to still stand up?" she says. "Maybe. Maybe not."—**ANNA GRACE LEE**

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OFF THE WALL
Zoe Latta and Mike Eckhaus were inspired by J.Crew's early, legendary catalogs.

SHAKING THE FOUNDATIONS

A new collaboration with Eckhaus Latta lends a sweet subversion to J.Crew's elevated staples. By Max Berlinger.

Zoe Latta's first recollection of J.Crew is from middle school, when she came across a Technicolor men's hand-knit sweater in one of the brand's legendary early catalogs. "It was just insane-looking," she recalls, "so many different colors, so Waspy—and *cool*." It changed the way the Northern California native, who grew up in a decidedly more bohemian milieu, saw the brand. "It was this burst-open American point of view," she says. "It really blew my mind."

That very sweater served as a touchpoint for J.Crew's new collaboration with Eckhaus Latta, the label that Latta oversees alongside her design partner, Mike Eckhaus (whose own first memory of the brand is of wearing the same J.Crew sweater vest as a classmate for their middle school book report on *The Catcher in the Rye*). Since founding Eckhaus Latta 15 years ago, they've built a mystique as scrappy downtown darlings specializing in a gritty, modern version of American sportswear, all earthy funk and sleek subversion.

If the linkup seems unexpected, well—that's the whole point. "We really celebrate the everyday," says Olympia Gayot, J.Crew's creative director and head of womenswear, "and then they come and add a twist, a tension. That's very exciting for us."

How else could J.Crew give us a chunky-knit skirt suit in a flecked acid yellow, like some wayward cousin of Chanel? (Latta says she was looking for "gross" colors, including a "puke green.") Elsewhere, there's a riff on the ladylike twinset, in striped cashmere, frisky in its cropped proportions; and classic oxford shirts, now slashed up the back, featuring a deep, overlapping vent. "Some things felt very us, others felt very J.Crew," Latta says of working together. "If it was one or the other, we'd get rid of it or push it toward the middle. Nothing that's in here feels preposterous to me. There's a person for all of it."

"There's this foundation with Eckhaus Latta of denim, jersey, and knitwear," Eckhaus says. "And I could say the same of J.Crew—they're just realized differently."

While he and Latta have made their name with wide-cut denim dyed in murky shades; shaggy, sculptural knits; and shirting with sexy-strange cutouts, in recent years their work has gained a finesse that comes with experience, and now includes handsome leathers and more streamlined silhouettes. Much like J.Crew's elevated staples, these are real clothes worn by real people in their real lives—though from the start, Eckhaus Latta has attracted a coterie of creative types (e.g., indie actors, gallerists) who often sit in their fashion shows' front row and, occasionally, are persuaded to walk their runway. >230

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THE POWER OF AN EYE

Photography by François Nars

NARS's Notorious Mascara marks a new era for the iconic beauty brand.

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Photographs by Marc Regas

Beauty begins with vision: the ability to see what others miss, to recognize possibility, and to transform a face into an image that lingers long after the camera clicks. Since collaborating on his first *Vogue* cover in 1985, makeup artist and NARS founder François Nars has worked alongside legendary photographers and designers to help define the visual mood of an era—one in which supermodels channeled an unmatched sense of energy, joy, and confidence.

Now, François Nars turns his eye to Kaia Gerber. In an homage to iconic *Vogue* covers of the past, the model of the moment stars in the campaign for NARS' new Notorious Mascara.

For François, the connection runs deeper than nostalgia. Gerber is "a supermodel of today who carries with her the spirit of another era," he says. Photographing her felt like "reliving the magic" of the original supers—a return to the optimism, artistry, and creative energy that first drew him to the industry and inspired some of fashion's most enduring makeup looks.

That same philosophy finds its latest expression in Notorious Mascara. Delivering eye-opening lift, length, and defined volume with a lightweight feel, the all-in-one formula feels delightfully next generation. For Gerber, the collaboration carries its own sense of history. NARS was "the very first makeup brand I ever bought," she says, adding that working with François was "both surreal and profoundly special."

It's the kind of effortless déjà vu that only a true artist can imbue. After all, beauty isn't just about what you see—it's about how you see it. And the magic you continue to create.

Discover the new NARS Notorious Mascara, available at Ulta.

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POWER TRIO
J.Crew's Olympia Gayot with Zoe Latta and Mike Eckhaus. "We celebrate the everyday," Gayot says, "and then they come and add a twist, a tension."

"What defines their brand is not only what they design, but the world that they build around it," observes Gayot, recalling a show where the casting director held a model's baby as she traipsed the catwalk, or the time a gaggle of friends provided full-throated musical accompaniment. "It's not pretentious—it's familial, it's beautiful, it's downtown," she continues. "It's like all of those things that you look at as an outsider, and you're like, 'I want to be part of that world.'"

Their 27-piece collaboration, which includes men's, women's, and children's pieces, comes on the heels of a smaller project earlier this year in which Eckhaus Latta reimagined J.Crew's signature roll-neck sweater, rendering it in earth-toned patches. The entire run sold out in a few hours. "We're not a hype brand—we're not used to putting something out and having it be gone," Eckhaus says. "But selling out that quickly was really fulfilling, and being able to expand that into a full collection feels exciting in a whole different way."

A lot of the work happened at J.Crew headquarters in downtown Manhattan, amid mood boards pinned with old campaign images, fabric swatches, and new sketches. "There's just so much inspiration," Eckhaus says of mining the J.Crew archives. "There's this wealth of things to explore and riff off of, and then subvert and digest and play with in a way that feels us."

"We had to keep asking, Does this still speak to the J.Crew customer?" Eckhaus continues. "How do you push the silhouette without it feeling alienating? How do you make it feel cool and very now while still being wearable?" Funnily enough, the collection as a whole embodies what Latta first felt all those years ago while flipping through the pages of a J.Crew catalog—an American perspective that isn't singular, but expansive, that somehow captures something ineffable about our kaleidoscopic sense of self. □

FRESH AS FABRIC

The new scents stitch together unusual influences.

Nose-deep in a nylon Prada shoulder bag is a strange way to start a Saturday morning in SoHo. But after taking a subtle whiff inside the purse—and hoping no one in the downtown Manhattan store was taking note—I sniff my wrist. Earlier, I had spritzed on Prada Beauty's latest scent, Nylon Noir. Sharp when it hits the nose, it reminds me of the sound that nylon makes when it rubs against itself.

SWEET SHEETS
Some materials, like cashmere, have long been a fragrance note, but what about cotton, linen, or silk?

We all know what tulle, satin, and wool look like—but how do they smell? That's what the latest fragrances are exploring. These aren't leather scents (new cars, edgy jackets, saddles), which have been done since 1781, when The House of Creed first made Royal English Leather for King George III. Instead, think of opening the doors to a fashion house's workshop and experiencing the materials. "Indigo is inspired by denim," Andrea Maack says of the newest perfume from her namesake company, which deploys notes of lavender, orris, and musk. It smells like how it feels to pull on my favorite pair of almost-too-tight vintage Gloria Vanderbilt jeans.

I find, as I test these new fragrances, that I gravitate toward those that match my outfit. A nipped-in 1950s fit and flare dress requires a Dior scent influenced by the sharp angles of the New Look, while a wiggle sheath and feathered mules worn to an American Ballet Theatre matinee prompt me to reach for YSL Beauty's Velours, inspired by the lush velvet beloved by Yves Saint Laurent. And the limited edition porcelain bottle of Dries Van Noten's Soie Malaquais—or "Malaquais Silk"—is slinky and sexy enough for a night out in a slip dress. When I return home, even my bath-and-bed routine is fabric-inspired; Guerlain's Eau de Coton is a soft blend of almond and orange blossom that's equally cozy on my pajamas and my sheets. Party on, and party down.—**MARGAUX ANBOUBA**

GAYOT, LATTA, AND ECKHAUS: COURTESY OF J.CREW. BED: PHOTOGRAPHED BY IRVING PENN, *VOGUE*, JANUARY 1991.

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THE GRIND

A stiff upper lip can be brutal for your teeth. Alessandra Codinha unlearns how to grit and bear it.

I knew I was in trouble when the drill came out. "We've got an issue," my dentist told me. "You've been clenching your jaw so hard you're killing your tooth. Possibly multiple." *Killing*?! Surely he was exaggerating: My dental records are historically cavity-free! And after a bout of COVID-era stress-grinding, I wear a night guard. "Pressure kills the nerve," he explained, pointing at my X-ray and a cloudy molar interior. "You've been clamping down, probably at night, but also probably during the day. Were you aware of that?" Reader, I had a baby seven months before this conversation, and I read the news. Was I *aware* that I was *tense*? I *sure was*! I just didn't think my teeth knew.

I'm not alone. Two partial crowns later, during a visit to my Los Angeles endodontist for the prescribed curative root canal required for a third, I learned that more and more patients are coming in with clenching and grinding calamities versus the traditional cavities that used to be the endodontist's bread and butter. And then these patients are coming back. Since COVID, my endodontist had seen people cracking through fillings and crowns made out of material that's supposed to be diamond-hard. He was considering offering masseter Botox injections to temporarily paralyze the largest jaw muscle for the worst repeat offenders. "I don't think it's a dentist's place to give Botox, but I'm running out of ideas," he told me.

In that, he is alone. It seemed that everywhere I looked, new businesses were cropping up to tackle the growing problem of our propensity to grin and bear it. A week later I was trying Emface, a high-intensity muscle-stimulation device that uses electromagnetic waves purportedly to retrain overactive facial and jaw muscles through a course of repeated sessions. What that looks like in practice is two stick-on pads attached to wires that cause your face to painlessly spasm for 20 minutes straight while you scroll on your phone. While I was lying there, a friend aware of my situation texted a link to a video of what appeared to be a woman being tortured but was in fact LeAnn Rimes getting her jaw worked on by a fascial maneuver coach. >252

UNDER PRESSURE

Clamping down, day and night, can wreak havoc on your teeth. Dentists are seeing people crack through materials meant to be indestructible.

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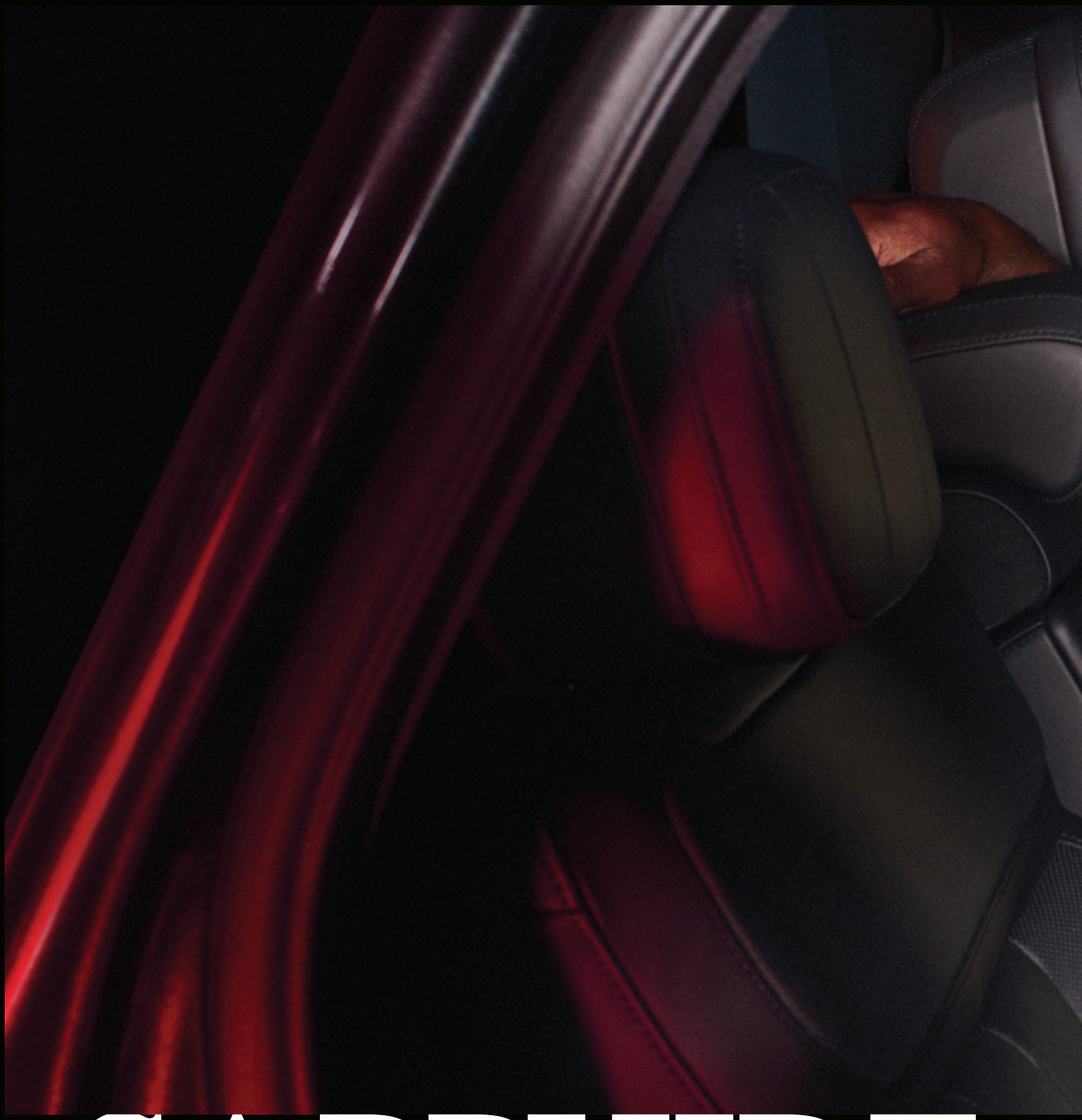

SAPPHIRE

RESERVE

Member FDIC

(These are experts in body work that targets the connective tissue which wraps around the body's muscles and organs.) I watched the singer bawl hysterically in—I guess—relief while I twitched, supine, behind a scrim in a Beverly Hills store window. Perhaps this all sounds ridiculous? There was a time I would have thought so. But that was before. I emailed LeAnn's fascia guy to see if they had any available slots. They did, but not many. "We're shooting our new TV show!" a rep wrote back.

He wasn't the only one who knew fascia. I enlisted sports medicine chiropractor Jenna Lagana, DC, for help. She specializes in performance rehab and has worked with multiple performing artists; singers, she told me, get jaw issues like baseball pitchers get elbow ones. Night guards intended to prevent grinding can sometimes compound clenching, she said. If presented with something to grip, even unconsciously, many jaws will. She assessed my situation manually: no clicking or popping or pain while chewing meant it wasn't a joint problem, but my jaw muscles were tight and aggrieved from overuse—a soft tissue issue. She applied pressure at various points around my skull and shoulders and did a sharply painful but ultimately relieving maneuver inside the upper corners of my mouth to get the hyperactive muscles there to relax a bit.

Once her hand was out of my mouth, I asked what she thought about Botox—would that let me skip a future of painful manual maneuvers? "I do *not* recommend that as an option," she told me. "It's not viable, it's not affordable long-term, and it's not a solution at all. I've never met anyone who's like, 'Oh yeah, *I got Botox one time and my jaw is totally better*.' What you need to do is find out what your stressors are," a.k.a. what's making me clench, "and how to mitigate those stressors and to improve the overall tone of your head, neck, jaw, all of that musculature." She recommended twice daily gua sha along the masseter, preferably with heat. And, you know, trying to *not* clench. "When you catch yourself doing it, put your tongue behind your upper teeth," Lagana's wife, Natazia zu Stolberg, a licensed acupuncturist, offered on my way out the door. "Remember, your teeth aren't supposed to touch unless you're chewing!" I practiced on my way to the car and realized that my teeth were *always* touching—a long-held horror of appearing slack-jawed may be subconsciously working against me.

I realized that my teeth were *always* touching—a long-held horror of appearing slack-jawed may be subconsciously working against me

"Oh, that could totally factor in," integrative and functional medicine expert Sarah Corey, ND, told me on a call later that week. "Think about the messaging we get" about being strong and unflappable: stiff upper lip, set your jaw, all of that. "People are *stressed*," she said, and she pointed out that the jaw is historically a place where we feel the strain. Animals in high-intensity situations—being chased on the savanna, say—will physically shake or tremble as a stress response once they've reached safety; people who get a horrendous work email or are cursed out by a driver on the freeway don't have anywhere to dump all of that cortisol and adrenaline. And not to stress anybody out further, but high cortisol suppresses your immune system and increases inflammation, both of which lead to things like quicker aging and poor long-term health outcomes.

"I think we need to look at this as not just what's happening in that specific muscle," Corey told me. "Are there things that you feel like you're not saying or you're holding back? Are there boundaries that we're not creating? I think that's a big one for women." (To be fair, I hadn't slept uninterrupted in over a month, but how was I going to lecture my baby about boundaries?) "When you're stressed and worried you're in sympathetic overdrive, which means you stop being able to rest and digest," and your body can't repair itself or reset its nervous system. Breath work, she advised me, is actually the only way we can force ourselves into the parasympathetic. (And it's free!) She directed me to breathe in through the nose for four seconds, hold for seven, and exhale through the mouth for nine. (You don't even have to count or hold, a breath work coach told me later, you just have to exhale longer than you inhale.) Corey also recommended significantly upping my intake of omega-3s for mood and joint health, and nightly magnesium glycinate for improved sleep.

So I had a plan. But what about the things that had already gone haywire? "Dr. Annie! She changed my life," stylist and wellness fanatic Djuna Bel told me. Bel glows with a kind of rude Californian health and goes once a week for chiropractic adjustments, including of her jaw. At Glendale's Healthwise Chiropractic clinic, Annie Issagholyan, DC, took a series of X-rays and measurements to show me that the problem was actually not in my head. It was in my spine. Nervous system dysregulation plus postural problems lead to a whole suite of dysfunctions, Issagholyan explained. Two thirds of the patients who come to see her are there because of jaw dysregulation, she told me, though the specifics can vary widely. "With temporomandibular joint (or TMJ) dysfunction, it's very rare for just one thing to be the cause." Poor sleep positioning plus "tech neck" (a forward tilt so-named because it aims the eyes downward at a device) was putting exponential volumes of pressure on my spine, which was showing up in my jaw, but also in my shoulders and hips.

Issagholyan built out a 24-session plan to course-correct, involving twice weekly visits in which I would be chiropractically adjusted, my jaw cold-lasered to promote cellular regeneration and my back muscles stimulated by electrodes. I would also do a neck traction exercise where I was yoked to the wall for 20 tilted squats. She would manually release the medial and lateral pterygoids, the small muscles inside my mouth, which were the worst offenders. She would also adjust my mid-back, where some shoddy form while baby-lifting was showing up, and finish by realigning my neck. On the way out after that first visit, I received ice packs for my face and was measured for a new, carefully designed pillow that promised to keep my head level.

I followed the plan. Results were tender but steady. I found myself newly aware of how I was positioning my head on my neck and holding my phone while I looked at it. I took my supplements and began and ended the day with intentionally deep breathing. And I realized one day that I was getting better. On one visit, Issagholyan painlessly snapped my head back and forth and, as the volley of pops of my neck vertebrae realigned, I felt something relax at the top of my skull; when I got off the table it took me a minute before I realized my teeth weren't touching. Hours later they still weren't.

Partway through the program, I asked what the future held. Was there ever a point when I'd be done? "We will get you stable," Issagholyan said. But cured? It doesn't work like that. "You don't go to the gym for three months and then say, 'There, I did it!'" A former dancer with a physical job in a very stressful world, she herself gets adjusted once a week and sees it as an important part of what keeps her healthy and able. "But maybe if life gets less stressful we won't need all of this intervention." For that, I won't be holding my breath. □

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Hotel Bennett: *Grand Romantic*

Polished, feminine and unapologetically glamorous. Think blush silk, statement earrings, elegant heels and a beautifully structured handbag.

Shop the Look: ***Croghan's Jewel Box***

The Cooper: *Modern Icon*

Elegant without being predictable. Think a beautifully draped dress, polished accessories and one striking statement piece.

Shop the Look: ***Shoes on King***

The Pinch: *Downtown Creative*

Understated, design-conscious and effortlessly current. Think wide-leg trousers, an oversized blazer, leather flats and an artful accessory.

Shop the Look: ***The Tiny Tassel***

The Spectator Hotel: *Classic Tailoring*

Timeless, discreet and finished with precision. Think a crisp white shirt, tailored trousers, loafers and an heirloom watch.

Shop the Look: ***Beau & Ro***

The Loutrel: *Garden Sophisticate*

Refined with a softer point of view. Think botanical prints, fluid tailoring, delicate gold jewelry and a touch of Charleston color.

Shop the Look: ***HART Jewelry***

Zero George: *Heritage Chic*

Romantic architecture balanced by quiet luxury. Think linen, vintage-inspired silhouettes, woven textures and understated jewelry.

Shop the Look: ***Madison Mathews***

Post House Inn: *Coastal Prep*

Relaxed, polished and subtly nostalgic. Think striped knits, tailored shorts, loafers and a classic trench.

Shop the Look: ***Gold Creations***

The Sanctuary at Kiawah Island Golf Resort: *Resort Elegance*

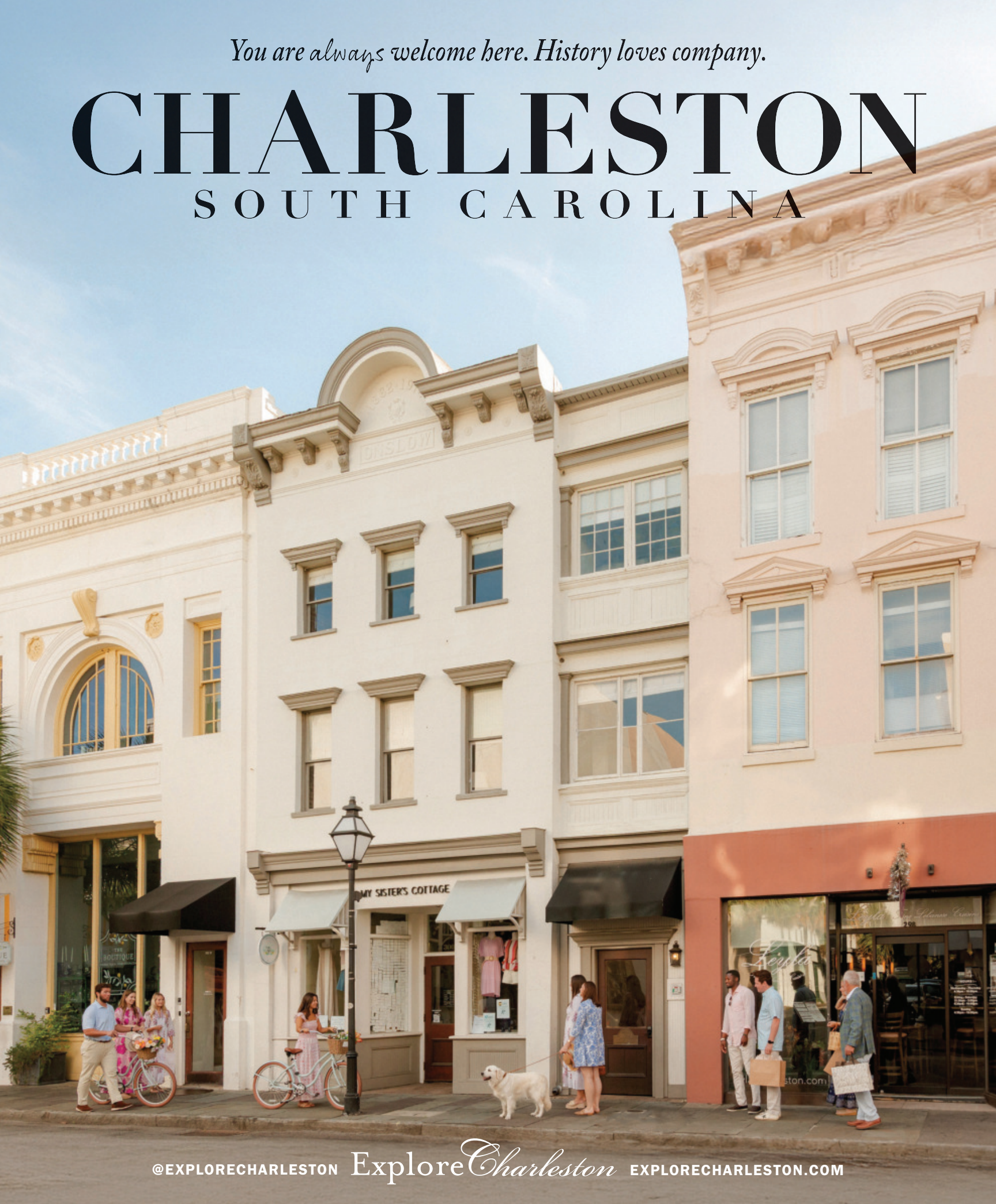
Graceful, composed and designed for a grand arrival. Think a flowing maxi dress, oversized sunglasses, woven accessories and evening-ready sandals.

Shop the Look: ***Charleston Shoe Company at Freshfields Village***

Wild Dunes Resort: *Coastal Sport*

Fresh, effortless and ready to move from beach to dinner. Think elevated separates, a lightweight knit, relaxed tailoring and a refined tote.

Shop the Look: ***Citrine Swim***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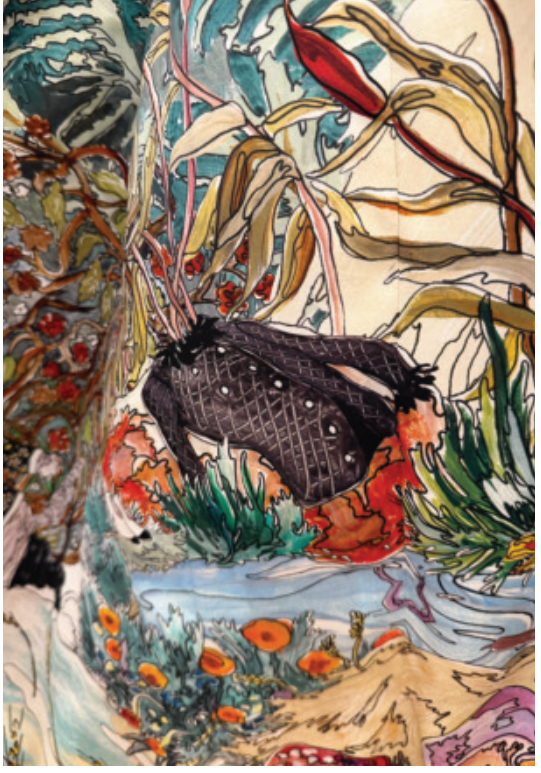

IT'S A WRAP

CLOCKWISE FROM LEFT: A silk-scarf party dress from Area's fall 2026 collection; a scarf detail from a fall 2026 Chanel couture look; Isaac Mizrahi's polka-dot-scarf accent in 1990.

FIT TO BE TIED

How fashion made the fusty silk scarf cool again.

Not that long ago, the notion of a silk scarf conjured images of something slightly fusty—the lingering scent of mothballs in a grandmother's dresser, equal parts cherished and outdated. There were, of course, flashes of Grace Kelly's Riviera chic still woven into its legacy, but for many of us, our cultural association came courtesy of *The White Lotus,* where Jennifer Coolidge's scarf prompted comparisons to Peppa Pig, not Monica Vitti.

Then the runways intervened. At Celine, Michael Rider is intent upon the accessory's revival. His inaugural show, circa June 2025, took place under an enormous silk scarf "tent," and by now, four collections in, the American in Paris has shown twill scarves looped around necks, tucked into blazers, and cascading off shoulders.

Inspired by the silk T-shirts worn as turbans at Sarah Burton's fall 2026 Givenchy, I've been tying on a silk scarf kerchief-style on days when I have too much dry shampoo in my hair. I also enjoy sporting the occasional sarong or a wispily tacked-on top motivated by the tropical-office vibe that Julian Klausner has conjured at Dries Van Noten—Manhattan *is* an island, after all. And seeing everyone from Alexa Chung to Jennifer Lawrence in their folded foulards turned cummerbunds, it seems I'm not alone.

Is all this a simple yearning for bygone glamour—or is it something more? Area's Nicholas Aburn has an inkling. "I think there's a collectible quality to scarves, which is really desirable," he says as we mull over a waterfall wall of scarves at the Stella Dallas vintage store in Williamsburg, Brooklyn. Also: "Scarves invite personalization." So much so that Aburn took inspiration from vintage examples to compose his own silk-scarf party dresses for Area's fall collection. Whether you tie it like a halter or a tube top, there's something exhilarating about being scantily clad in the finest tissue you can find.

Aburn himself is partial to what he calls a "Stefano Pilati," which conjures an image of the former Saint Laurent creative director's tucked-into-a-T-shirt scarf-wearing style. He grabs a greenish-brown paisley foulard and begins fiddling around to give it a perfect worn-in wrinkle before snapping, tucking, and tying for that exact Pilati twist. For me, he selects a geometric pastel creation in the vein of classic Hermès, where Nadège Vanhée has recently wound kerchiefs around gold chain-link necklaces.

"That really hits the spot," he says, surveying the results. "You can do so many different things. It can be this sartorial menswear vibe one day, and Palm Beach the next."—ALEXANDRA HILDRETH

AREA: GORUNWAY. CHANEL: SAM SUSSMAN. MODEL JOANNA RHODES: PHOTOGRAPHED BY TIZIANO MAGNI, *VOGUE*, FEBRUARY 1990.

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CHARACTER STUDY

A forgotten polymath of the Pop art movement gets an overdue tribute. By Grace Edquist.

Rosalyn Drexler wrote her first novel on a dare. Up till then she was known mostly as an avant-garde sculptor and painter in New York. But after the editor Richard Grossman, then launching his own publishing house, read a few paragraphs she drafted on a lark in the early 1960s, he was impressed enough that he offered the amateur writer a book contract. "You do know that I've never written a novel," Drexler told him. "Well, you will," he countered.

She made good on his bet. Based on her 1940s adolescence in the Bronx, *I Am the Beautiful Stranger,* brought out by Grossman Publishers in 1965, was deemed a "subtly liberating," "wholly original," and "enormously replenishing" novel by *The New York Times Book Review.* The Beat poet Gregory Corso wrote to Drexler after reading it, thanking her for writing such an "honest and compelling" book.

Drexler, who died last year at the age of 98, had a life full of such improbable triumphs. She was the kind of creative polymath who excelled at most things she attempted. A self-taught painter, she brought an incisive feminist perspective to the burgeoning genre of Pop art. She won an Obie Award for the first theater piece she ever wrote, 1964's *Home Movies* (which Susan Sontag called "fast and witty"); she was on the Emmy-winning writing team, along with Lorne Michaels and Richard Pryor, for Lily Tomlin's 1973 television special; and she received a Guggenheim fellowship (for fiction) and one from MacDowell (for painting). She even had a stint as a professional wrestler—its own kind of performance art.

"At that time, in the '60s and '70s, you were supposed to pick a lane," says Garth Greenan, whose New York City gallery has represented Drexler since 2015 and who will stage a greatest-hits show in September. The exhibition will include Drexler's writing and art but also personal correspondence and home movies she made with her husband, the late painter Sherman Drexler. "I want to put every ounce of steam that I can behind Rosalyn," Greenan says.

Rosalyn Bronznick was born in the Bronx in 1926, the oldest of three daughters raised by parents of Russian Jewish descent. She was a precocious kid and attended the High School of Music & Art (now LaGuardia). She met Sherman in Van Cortlandt Park—at the time she was studying with a dance group—and married him at 19, dropping out of Hunter College after one semester. At 20 she had her first child: a daughter, Rachel. Her son, Daniel, was born 11 years later.

Drexler's brief foray into professional wrestling was partly to escape the constraints of domestic life. "I've got to get away from this family thing for a while," she told the critic John Yau in 2007. She joined an all-women troupe and chose the wrestling nickname Rosa Carlo, the Mexican Spitfire (a stretch for a Jewish girl from the Bronx). For a few months she toured with the group across the South, leaving Sherman and a young Rachel at home. She didn't love life on the road, but it made for good material for her rollicking third novel, *To Smithereens,* published in 1972. (She was later the subject, as wrestler Rosa Carlo, of a Warhol silkscreen print.)

Back in New York, she hung out at the Cedar Bar, the famed Greenwich Village dive, with friends like Willem and Elaine de Kooning >268

MANY COLORS

Rosalyn Drexler's work spanned painting, pro wrestling, and novel-writing. FROM TOP: *Lovers,* 1963, acrylic and paper collage on canvas; Drexler as Rosa Carlo, the Mexican Spitfire, circa 1950; *Lost Match,* 1962, acrylic and paper collage on canvas board.

DREXLER: PHOTOGRAPH BY SHERMAN DREXLER. ALL IMAGES: COURTESY OF GARTH GREENAN GALLERY, NEW YORK. © 2026 ROSALYN DREXLER/ARTISTS RIGHTS SOCIETY (ARS), NEW YORK. *LOST MATCH:* COLLECTION OF ROSE ART MUSEUM AT BRANDEIS UNIVERSITY.

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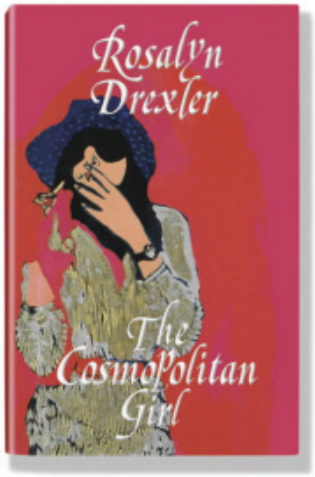
and began showing found object sculptures. Her solo show in 1960 at the experimental Reuben Gallery in the East Village marked her official entry onto the city's art scene. But when the gallery closed in 1961, she couldn't find a new one to represent her, so she pivoted to painting, hoping that might give her a better chance.

She became a Pop art pioneer, gluing enlarged ads she found in magazines and newspapers onto canvas before painting over them in vivid tones. "It was naive, but it worked," Drexler reflected in a 2017 essay. She placed her subjects at odd, sometimes extreme, angles, and she was particularly drawn to images that captured the gendered power dynamics in romantic relationships. Her two requirements for anything she made were that it had to be honest and it had to amuse her. Beyond that, she wasn't all that interested in what others thought.

"I think Drexler is almost alone among artists of her generation in pointing to physical violence against women as a casual part of the media landscape," says Katy Siegel, the co-curator of a retrospective that opened at the Rose Art Museum at Brandeis University in 2016. Drexler never publicly disclosed whether her interest in the topic was born out of her own experience. Her point was that aggression was all around us, deeply embedded in American culture.

By the mid-1960s, she turned her focus to writing. In addition to her award-winning plays and novels, she wrote occasional film reviews, including for this magazine. "She was so out of the box in her perceptions," says the poet and musician Joy Harjo, who became close friends with Drexler at the Iowa Writers' Workshop in 1976, when Drexler was on the faculty and Harjo was pursuing her MFA. Both women felt like outsiders at the prestigious institution, and Harjo was drawn to Drexler's irreverence. "She was my place of sanity when I was trying to find my way."



LADY IN RED
Drexler's *Chain Smoker* (1960) on the cover of the new edition of her 1974 novel.

The limelight started to fade in the 1980s. Drexler's art wasn't shown as much. But in the last decade or so before her death, new champions (including the writer Jonathan Lethem) pulled her back into the zeitgeist. Rachel Comey, who dove into Drexler's archive for inspiration for her spring 2027 collection, has newly joined the list of admirers, as has Hagfish, an indie publishing house run by 30-somethings Naomi Huffman and Julia Ringo that reissues out-of-print books. "We were looking for something loud and fresh, something unusual, something to really help us establish the voice of the project," says Huffman. They published *To Smithereens* as their first title last spring, and this fall they'll reissue Drexler's 1974 madcap satire *The Cosmopolitan Girl,* about a woman in a relationship with her talking dog.

If there was a downside to all of Drexler's multi-hyphenating, it's that she was never fully at home in one discipline. "She kind of did it all, but she did say to me that she was always there, but she was never *there*," says Adam Harrison Levy, a writer and filmmaker at work on a documentary about Drexler. Maybe that's her true transgression: She refused to commit to just one thing. "She wanted to write her own story," Greenan says, "which speaks to all the different roles that she played in the theater that was her life." □

BALTIC-BOUND
Thatched-roof structures on Eha's property, located on the island of Hiiumaa.

ISLAND TIME

An imaginative resort opens in an unspoiled Estonian landscape.

You've heard of spring, summer, fall, and winter. But what about *viies aastaaeg*? Across southern Estonia in late March, as the ice thaws and the Baltic mists shift, a micro-season is created—one that Eha, a new retreat on the island of Hiiumaa, has termed "springrise." The island "has its own rhythm," says the Tallinn-born Eva Maran, who has spent the past five years developing Eha alongside her partner, Sonny Aswani. "Nothing can be forced."

Hiiumaa, which is a UNESCO Biosphere Reserve, has miles of white-sand beaches and moss-carpeted forests, dotted with traditional timber farmhouses and medieval stone churches. It's long served as a popular summer getaway for Estonians (think a wilder Martha's Vineyard), who have recently prospered thanks to Tallinn's tech boom. When I visited this summer, families could be spotted hopping onto sailboats or gathering outside the beachside restaurants for smoked fish and cold beers.

After a morning spent planting chaga mushrooms in the woods and a spot of seal-watching off the island's northern shores, I arrived at Eha: An octagonal, thatched-roof architectural wonder, it roosts above a tidal stream on the edge of an ancient pine forest, where blue-black barn swallows (the Estonian national bird) chirp among the reeds. "In Estonia, nature is a religion, and the forest is our church," notes Maran. In September guests will arrive here for multi-night wellness programs, with a focus on resetting circadian patterns and traditional activities like birch sauna, foraging, and even apitherapy. "So much of modern life pulls us away from our own rhythm," Maran adds. "At Eha, I hope people feel that rhythm slowly returning."—LIAM HESS

THE COSMOPOLITAN GIRL COVER: CLAIRE HUNGERFORD/ COURTESY OF HAGFISH. EHA: COURTESY OF EHA RETREAT.

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FUTURE PROMISE

Thrilling new fiction looks at what's to come.

Arriving almost a decade after she published the best-selling *Pachinko,* Min Jin Lee's **American Hagwon (Cardinal)** is nominally about the Korean obsession with education. A hagwon is a for-profit school (sometimes a "cram school") attended by students after school or on weekends, and in Lee's new novel it's a California outpost that is the repository of her characters' hope, determination, and occasional despair. The Koh family has ended up in Southern California after a series of misfortunes causes them to fall from a comfortable upper-middle-class life to a hardscrabble American existence. Lee builds a world for this family that is as dense and intricate as that of a 19th-century novel, and with similar themes—class, ambition, and autonomy—woven throughout. There is a warm and enveloping charm to Lee's writing; no matter how current the specifics of the predicament, some struggles are timeless.—CHLOE SCHAMA

Across his first two novels—*In the Distance* (2017) and the Pulitzer Prize–winning *Trust* (2022)—Hernan Diaz examined two pillars of American history: the Wild West and Wall Street. In **Ply (Riverhead)**, he turns his gaze to the future. Set a few hundred years from now, the novel takes place in a dystopian East Coast metropolis (guess which…) bisected along class lines, overrun by nature, and in which electricity has become a black market currency. The protagonist is a "pincher," illegally tapping into the grid to fuel an underground punk music and arts scene. As she's drawn to a mysterious, radical physicist—who is covertly experimenting with a device that promises to unknit the fabric of space-time itself—questions around identity, capitalism, and chosen family arise. While it retains the epic sweep of Diaz's previous novels, *Ply* also marks a departure with the density of its inventive vernacular. But for those willing to go along for the ride, it's a page-turning, pleasurably disorienting, and deeply humane vision of a possible future.—LIAM HESS

Emma Cline captured a kind of youthful anomie in her second novel, *The Guest*—a book about a grifterish woman hiding out in the Hamptons. The flickering end of adulthood, not the messy, sexy start of it, is the subject of her new novel, **Switzy (Random House)**, a story situated in another rarefied realm: the cosseted existence of a financial titan. David Hastings is his name, and, with his aged brain failing, he's on a farewell swing from London to Zurich, where assisted suicide awaits. Cline's simple, detailed prose has tensile strength, and she vividly captures her protagonist's regrets and ambivalences and the pathos of a mind slipping away.—TAYLOR ANTRIM

Emily St. John Mandel became a literary superstar after *Station Eleven,* a post-pandemic-set work of science fiction that for a particular time seemed an eerie evocation of a fate that might await us all. In her new novel, **Exit Party (Knopf)**, the sci-fi is more metaphysical, involving parallel universes that chart alternative trajectories for society: one in which militias and territories have carved out martial authority; another in which a centralized surveillance-state power has consolidated control. Variations on the same characters occupy each domain—a masterful sketch of what is internal to a person and how their environment shapes them. Mandel crafts her cast of personalities with remarkable economy; despite the fluidity of the narrative, these individuals feel layered and complex. Very few writers world-build with such compact skill, the suspense enmeshed in every line.—C.S.

PAGE BY PAGE

FROM LEFT: Cover details from *American Hagwon, Ply, Switzy,* and *Exit Party.*

AMERICAN HAGWON: COURTESY OF CARDINAL. *PLY*: COURTESY OF RIVERHEAD BOOKS. *SWITZY*: COURTESY OF RANDOM HOUSE. *EXIT PARTY*: COURTESY OF PENGUIN RANDOM HOUSE.

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Just Kids

Kaia Gerber and Homer Gere have the good fortune of famous parents and flourishing careers—including starring roles in summer's alluring Bret Easton Ellis adaptation, *The Shards.* But they both know that making their own way means being utterly, unapologetically themselves. By Rob Haskell. Photographed by Steven Meisel.

In his best-selling 2024 book, *The Anxious Generation,* the social psychologist Jonathan Haidt argued that today's adolescents, flowering in a hothouse paned in iPhone glass, lack the exposure to chance and accident—not to mention to one another—that tends to produce daring, adaptable, and independent adults. Haidt, who is the same age as the writer Bret Easton Ellis, waxes nostalgic for many of the freedoms enjoyed in Ellis's 2023 novel, *The Shards.* But probably not all of them. While Haidt bemoans the current generation's lack of what he calls "free play," meandering and unsupervised, Ellis's young protagonists play with an abandon that verges on recklessness. The kids in *The Shards* might benefit from an occasional watchful eye, if only their parents weren't vacationing in Europe indefinitely.

This month Ryan Murphy brings his adaptation of *The Shards* to FX, and for those still floating on the '90s reverie of *Love Story,* his chronicle of the courtship, marriage, and tragic end of John F. Kennedy Jr. and Carolyn Bessette, here is another occasion for sensory time travel, to a world even more pleasingly analog, with even tighter jeans. Ellis's setting is Los Angeles in 1981, when the lives of a group of seniors at an elite private school are disrupted by a new student with a shadowy past. These kids are fast, weaving through the canyon in luxury cars, snorting cocaine, throwing sumptuous parties at their parents' houses, peacocking, fornicating, clubbing, and country-clubbing. All the while, a serial killer known as the Trawler is targeting young women from the city's wealthy neighborhoods.

The show's ensemble is anchored by Igby Rigney, who plays Bret (Ellis's younger self, more or less), an aspiring writer, closeted, whose girlfriend, Debbie Schaffer, is the daughter of a major Hollywood producer. But it's Kaia Gerber as Susan Reynolds, Bret's best friend, and Homer Gere as Robert Mallory, the mysterious new arrival, who give the show's credit sequence its frisson. Gerber's mother is, of course, Cindy Crawford, and Gere's father is Richard Gere; together they were among the iconic couples of the early '90s. (Indeed, they were photographed by Herb Ritts for the November 1992 cover of this magazine.)

DOUBLE TAKE

Gerber and Gere in Dior. They play two of the rich, disaffected 1980s LA teenagers in Ryan Murphy's new series *The Shards.* Fashion Editor: Spencer Singer.

LAYER CAKE
Gerber in Prada.
OPPOSITE:
Bottega Veneta dress and hat.

BEAUTY NOTE
The long game. Nars Notorious Mascara coats and conditions lashes with a new formula featuring nourishing argan oil.

"You watch *The Shards,* and it makes you long for a time when you could get into a little bit of trouble without it being on the internet the next day," Gerber says

"Maybe it seems too on the nose," Homer Gere says of this next-gen casting coup. He remembers meeting Gerber for the first time, along with a few other *Shards* cast members, at Ye Rustic Inn in Los Feliz. "That's Kaia's spot. It's, like, her chill I'm-gonna-go-have-a-beer-and-smoke-a-cig-outside spot. Twenty minutes into knowing each other, I was like, 'Should we just acknowledge the fact that our parents were married?' She was like, 'Yeah. Cool.' And that was it."

Gere has brought me to the Noguchi Museum, an ivy-clad fortress occupying a quiet triangular block of Long Island City, Queens. It's an important place for him, not merely because it houses an arresting collection of the Japanese American artist's abstract carved-stone and basalt sculptures. Gere, who was a visual arts major at Brown, came to know the museum when he produced a painstaking replica of one of Isamu Noguchi's paper lamps for an architecture class. It's an unusually hot late-spring afternoon, and he is wearing blue USA rugby shorts that he thrifted last week in Rome, a T-shirt he stole from his dad's closet that was a long-ago gift from Bruce Weber, and a beat-to-hell New York Yankees cap. This is his first interview, he tells me. He admits that he is nervous and adds that someone advised him to avoid sarcasm because it doesn't translate well in print.

"I just want to appear likable," he says ingenuously. "I talked to my dad about this, and he said, 'You're playing a character even when you're yourself in some way.' You know? I understand the game a little more, I think, than a person who has done as little work as I have should. I grew up in the most normal possible situation given who my father was. I didn't grow up in the industry at all. I had never been on a professional set until last summer."

Gere and Gerber could not have come to *The Shards* with more different CVs. Gerber began modeling at 10 and was 16 when she walked a major runway. She has had roles in two previous Ryan Murphy productions, among other television and film work, and Murphy had her in mind for the role of Susan, the beautiful and brainy student body president, as soon as *The Shards* was greenlit. Gere's arrival at acting was desultory, though maybe inevitable. He grew up in Pound Ridge, New York, with Richard Gere and his mother, the actress Carey Lowell. Though his parents divorced when he was 13, he remembers his childhood as "idyllic." Richard, who was 50 when Homer was born, made a point of building a family away from Hollywood. Upstate, Homer was raised essentially as an only child, though he is in fact one of seven siblings in a complex blended family: He has stepbrothers aged 36 and 40; a half sister aged 36; a stepbrother aged 13; and two half brothers, six and seven. On his mother's side, he is the youngest; on his father's side, the oldest.

"I was not a theater kid at all," he recalls. "Not. At. All. I was a jock. I mean, I think I was a sensitive jock! But I had grown up my entire childhood with people asking, 'Are you gonna be an actor when you're older?' And I was like, 'Fuck no.' I was good in school, and I had no pressure from my parents. Acting was always over there"—he flicks his hand to the side—"it was some other thing that other people did. There are a million happy lives that you can live, you know? And it's a complicated life. I think I knew that firsthand."

In college, Gere marched from major to major before discovering that he liked to make art. During the pandemic, he took a gap year, driving across the country and falling madly in love with the outdoors. Sport climbing is Gere's passion. He relishes the challenge of working through difficult predicaments in nature in highly controlled ways. Climbing runs in the bloodline: His maternal grandfather, the geologist James Lowell, has scaled every 14,000-foot mountain in Colorado, and, at 26, Gere has made it up 11 out of 52.

Back on campus in the fall of 2022, when he was a junior, a friend asked him to act in a short student film. "All of a sudden I was involved in the film community on campus," he remembers. "And every semester from then on, that was my main focus. I was trying to make sketches with my friends or, you know, how many sets can I be a part of? Can I do production design for you guys? Can I do location scouting? I just wanted to be on a team." Gere graduated in 2024 despite a concussion sustained playing club soccer that caused him to miss his final exams. After some time at home with his mother in Katonah, New York, and not seeing a clear path forward for himself, he spent a few months in Colorado, camping, hiking, and climbing. That's when he got an out of the blue call from a talent manager who had seen one of his student films and wanted to know if he was interested in representation. "I was like, Okay, maybe this is a sign."

To this point, Gere's exposure to Los Angeles had taken the form of Ed Limato, his father's legendary agent, pulling up to his childhood home in Pound Ridge. The door of Limato's limousine would open, and a cloud of cigarette smoke, like a breath of Old Hollywood, would herald his emergence. Homer and his father have not talked much about acting. Instead they tend to discuss the politics of the set and the perils of celebrity. "I'm an introvert who has developed enough social skills to function," he says. "I think my dad is the same."

Gere's parents both have enduring affiliations with Tibetan Buddhism, and its teachings have left an immovable mark. "Having a father who practices meditation—and in particular compassion

SWING TIME

The Shards is Gerber's third project with Murphy, who immediately had her in mind for a role. Gerber wears Chanel.

STEP UP
Valentino dress, Gigi Burris Millinery hat, and Herbert Levine shoes. Cartier earrings. OPPOSITE: Dolce & Gabbana suit.

THE PARENT TRAP

When Gerber and Gere first met as castmates, "I was like, 'Should we just acknowledge the fact that our parents were married?' " Gere says. "She was like, 'Yeah. Cool.' And that was it." Both wear Saint Laurent by Anthony Vaccarello.

ORANGE AND THE NEW BLACK

Balenciaga coat. Noel Stewart hat. Herbert Levine boots. OPPOSITE: Louis Vuitton dress, hat, and necklace.

"I think doubting yourself a bit is healthy, no matter how good you are. You should always be a little nervous if you're doing something worthwhile," Gere says

meditation—an hour a day for the last 50 years definitely affects you," he says. "It gives you a window into the real work that you can do on yourself. I didn't know my dad when he was in his 20s, but I think he was kind of a brat." He laughs. "He's grown a lot. That's the whole game, isn't it? You're never a finished product. For me the biggest lesson of Buddhism is the basic attitude of non-harming. It's like, you want to wish everyone the best of whatever that version is for them. No matter what the vibe is. Whether it's someone you like, someone you don't like, it just makes life a lot easier to move through."

He auditioned for two series in the spring of 2025, *Euphoria* and *The Shards,* and he and his father were in India for the Dalai Lama's birthday celebration when he got a call from Murphy's team asking him to come for a screen test. He flew to Los Angeles, landed the part of Robert Mallory, and two weeks later also got the role of Dylan Reid, a TV star who ends up the target of Cassie's sexual opportunism, in *Euphoria.* "In September I drove cross-country, moved into the Villa Carlotta, and suddenly I'm doing a bedroom scene with Sydney Sweeney," Gere recalls. "It was fucking crazy."

Gerber was surprised to find herself the most seasoned of the *Shards* ensemble. Hayes Warner, who plays Debbie, is a singer with no previous TV or film credits. Graham Campbell, who plays Susan's boyfriend, Thom Wright, is also on TV for the first time. "Fame was something that I was born into, so I didn't experience what it was like to *become* famous," Gerber explains. "I kind of thought that my way of being raised was the most anonymous it could get under the circumstances, and then I met Homer. Like, there are no photos of him as a child online, whereas my entire childhood and teenage years are on the internet. I can only imagine. I'm 24 but…very interviewed."

We are sitting at the Chateau Marmont, a sentimental place for Gerber since it housed the writers room for *The Shards* and was the setting for cast dinners presided over by Murphy, almost in loco parentis. Gerber tells a different story about her first meeting with Gere and their other castmates at her favorite dive bar last summer. Gere walked in late (Gerber, like her mother, is famously punctual) wearing a hat and a grin, and she thought, Wow, he's *so* like his character. "I think Homer has Robert's charisma without his cruelty," she says. "I looked around, and I said to the group, 'You guys are all so much like your characters. That's so interesting, since I'm nothing like mine.' Which was so dumb. They all looked at me, and they go, 'Hmm. No, I don't think you're the exception.' Susan is a lot more like me than I want to admit."

Gerber's current life in Los Angeles exists mostly outside the orbit of her Malibu childhood. "Unfortunately all the things that people assume are true," she says. "I was in the ocean every day. My brother would go surfing and then walk up to school in his wetsuit with his surfboard, barefoot. You're with the same kids from preschool to when you graduate. There were no Ubers there, so your parents were driving you to parties and then picking you up. There was only so much trouble you could get into."

In other words, though she was first photographed by Steven Meisel as a 13-year-old, Gerber does not recognize much of her own adolescence in Susan and her precocious clique. But she certainly remembers feeling like a brave little adult at 17, in New York with her own apartment, too proud to call her mother when she couldn't figure out how to turn on the dishwasher. In fact, her parents' visibility may have acted as a safeguard against wildness. "I never wanted to embarrass them," she recalls. "I never wanted to be that child coming in and ruining all the hard work they've done. I wasn't a partier in high school. My mom was valedictorian, so I was like, Okay, well then me too. I was the student that was like, 'You forgot to assign homework!' That didn't make me very popular. Really I was thinking, This is temporary. I don't want to do anything that will potentially mess up my life and career. I always had big dreams. But you watch *The Shards,* and it makes you long for a time when you weren't on your phone and where you could get into a little bit of trouble without it being on the internet the next day."

Modeling was the path laid out for her, but Gerber always wanted to be an actor, and she has applied herself with characteristic gusto. She has studied Meisner and Strasberg. Last spring, while her peers were at Paris Fashion Week, she was playing an emotionally brittle young woman in Will Arbery's *Evanston Salt Costs Climbing* at the 99-seat Matrix Theatre in West Hollywood. "My character is struggling with suicidal thoughts every night, and then I'd walk out and people are holding pictures of me posing naked as a teenager, asking me to sign them," she remembers. "It's like, I want to bleed out for people, and then I'm sort of hit in the face with this other thing."

Her older brother Presley Gerber's decade-long struggle with drug addiction appears to have provided a sort of foil as Kaia was discovering who she was. "When something like that happens in a family, it kind of levels everyone," she explains. "I think that's also why I started to self-identify as the easy one and never wanted to ask for help. Because it felt like too much to have two children who were needing." Last December, Presley opened up about his struggles in an Instagram video. Kaia, who has pursued multiple therapeutic modalities and is a champion of psychedelic therapy, in particular,

SUITS HIM

"I can't watch myself," says Gere, still new to acting. "It's a whole thing." Gere wears Giorgio Armani.

WHITE HOT
Gerber in Givenchy by Sarah Burton. Church's shoes. OPPOSITE: Loewe top and dress. Manolo Blahnik shoes. Chanel Fine Jewelry earrings and rings.

Gerber wishes she could be synonymous with her work, a trick some screen stars, such as her idol Gena Rowlands, managed. "To me that's the ultimate flex"

is deeply proud of him. "My parents for most of our lives were very, very private and didn't share anything—and now we have this absolute teacher, my brother, who says, 'I'm gonna be very human for everyone.' There's only so much you can hide from the world. And trying to put a lid on something just makes the person feel like you're ashamed of them."

Gerber, who quickly exhausted Malibu High School's independent study track—available mainly to people on the surf team but also to the occasional supermodel—passed her high school equivalency exam at age 16. And so she loved having a chance to play homecoming queen and class president in *The Shards.* (Gerber confesses that she ran for president herself in the fifth grade and lost.) She remembers how excited she was when Murphy told her to ad-lib a speech for a school assembly. "I know it was, like, 200 background actors who were paid to cheer for me, but it didn't matter," she says. "I was thinking, I have been waiting for this moment my whole life."

A few days after Gerber and I sit down, the Supreme Court throws out a lower court order calling for a new trial for the man convicted of the 1979 murder of Etan Patz. For children and parents of the 1980s, Patz's disappearance—a six-year-old leaves his SoHo apartment and is never seen again—signaled a newly dangerous universe.

Ryan Murphy had Patz in mind when he read *The Shards,* whose tense ambiance is rooted in the real-life paranoia of Southern California at the dawn of the '80s, a golden age of serial murder. The Night Stalker, the Hillside Stranglers, the Toolbox Killers, the Freeway Killer, and the Golden State Killer held the region in their grips, and yet in a certain milieu, at least, teenagers had rarely enjoyed so much freedom. "I never saw my parents," Murphy recalls of his own childhood in Indiana in the 1970s. "We ran around like wild children. Then everything changed. The year *The Shards* is set, 1981, was arguably the most important year of my life. I was a sophomore in high school. I was struggling with my sexuality. I lost my virginity, and, in July of 1981, in *The New York Times* there was the first announcement of AIDS. That was the year that I linked sexuality with the threat of death, as so many gay men did. I remember asking Bret, 'Is the Trawler really AIDS? Is HIV the real monster here?' He just smiled and said, 'My work is open to interpretation.'"

If *Love Story* is a meditation on life pre-9/11, *The Shards* is its pre-AIDS corollary. The material struck a deep chord in Murphy, who shared with his young cast his own experience growing up in the wake of Studio 54's decadence and on the cusp of AIDS. "That's such an important aspect of the book," he explains, "this idea that there was suddenly a price to be paid for the joy and freedom of a beautiful adolescence. The ultimate bogeyman of my childhood was AIDS, so I really tried to put that in the show. But I wasn't really prepared for how emotional I got when I directed it. I was shocked by how many times I would read a line or hear a song and burst into tears. I was always feeling the trauma of my youth."

It was a look backward for Murphy, but also a reflection on the ills of contemporary life, especially for the young. Murphy, a parent to three children, the oldest of whom is 13, tells me, "There's something about *The Shards* that says: Maybe the world was better when it was pre-digital." He made his cast leave their phones in their trailers for hours in the hope that they might build connections. By all accounts it was successful: Gere and Gerber say that the cast has remained uncommonly close. (The night before our trip to the museum, the two were dancing at Joyface in the East Village until 3 a.m.)

Though he met his girlfriend of the last year and a half on Hinge, Gere does not use social media. Gerber has found her way out of the dark corners of the internet that used to preoccupy her. "You'd read something nice about yourself," she says, "and then scroll and find something that's going to obliterate you. But it learns you very well. Now my TikTok is kind of a pleasant place: It's cooking videos and fishing-gear reviews and old men singing folk songs."

Murphy thinks that Gere will be a big star in spite of himself. "He has a quality that I like in an actor, which is a real sense of mystery. He has no interest in being famous. He's interested in the work of acting, and I love that about him. Kaia is so knowing. She's been around the block, and although she reads more than anyone I've ever met in my life, she is also so pop-culture savvy. Homer is nothing like that. I think he'll stay pure." To that end, after shooting Oliver Stone's new film, *White Lies,* in June, Gere headed into a 10-day Vipassana, or silent meditation, retreat in central Massachusetts. He has no other projects in the pipeline, and his agent understood that he would really and truly not be checking his phone. Before he went out of pocket, though, he learned that still images from *Euphoria* in which he is wearing nothing but underwear had gone viral. The internet, it turned out, was busy praising the soft contours of his physique (some called it "natural," others dubbed it a "dad bod").

"The fact that I'm apparently a body-positivity icon has opened my eyes to the absurdity of the media," he tells me later by text (though my sense is that his eyes were already wide open). Gerber, whose body has been sliced and diced by CONTINUED ON PAGE 372

ON THE BUTTON

Gerber wears Marc Jacobs. Mikimoto necklace. In this story: hair, Guido Palau; makeup, Pat McGrath. Details, see In This Issue.

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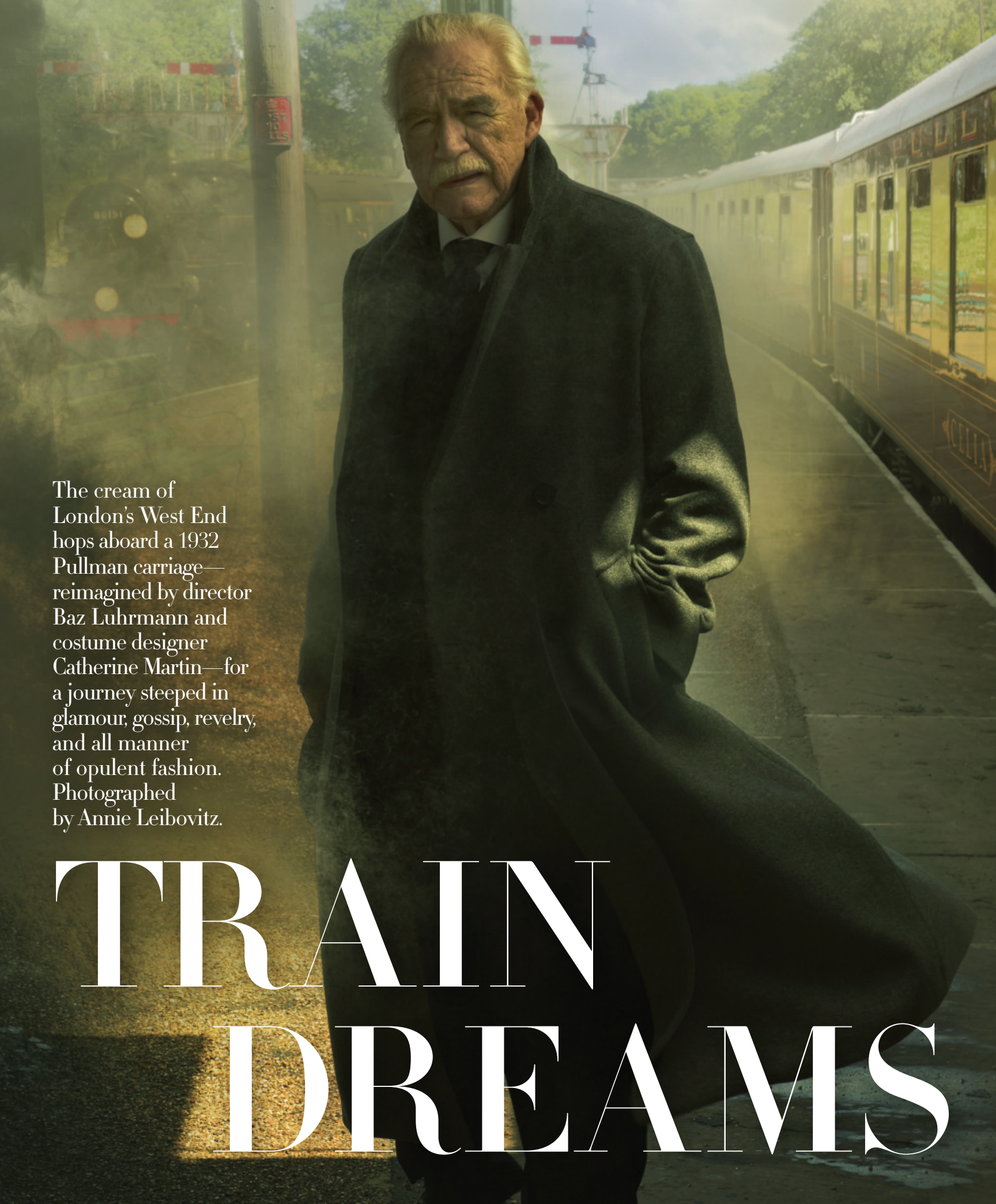

The cream of London's West End hops aboard a 1932 Pullman carriage—reimagined by director Baz Luhrmann and costume designer Catherine Martin—for a journey steeped in glamour, gossip, revelry, and all manner of opulent fashion. Photographed by Annie Leibovitz.

TRAIN DREAMS

TICKET TO RIDE
FROM LEFT: Brian Cox, in **Paul Smith,** will reprise his West End performance as J.S. Bach in *The Score* when it comes to Washington, DC, in September. "It feels more pertinent now," he says, "and even more ironic exploring corruption in Washington, given who is running the show." Letitia Wright wears a **Max Mara** dress. Josephine Thiesen wears **Akris.**
Fashion Editor: Tabitha Simmons.

RUNNING THE SHOW
Luke Thompson (in an **Emporio Armani** waistcoat, shirt, and trousers) returns to the London stage in Robert Icke's adaptation of *The Lives of Others* in October. Theater, he says, is "not a methodical job to me—it's instinctive. When people are asking you how you do it up there, it's like asking how you stay alive."

It's

"It's about power," says Harriet Walter, the 75-year-old theatrical legend, on the first hot day of an English summer, finger sandwich in hand, yellowing fields of West Sussex wilting away through the train windows behind her. "The regime change, the morality of war…," she plows on, in floor-length Dolce & Gabbana Alta Moda, "…the brutal decisions that have to be made."

Actor Archie Madekwe leans in, enraptured by her take on Phyllida Lloyd's all-women *Julius Caesar,* which opens in Stratford (with Walter as Brutus) this November. Madekwe, 31, is already deep in his run of Simon Stone's *The Oresteia* at London's The Bridge.

When Madekwe lets slip to the actors aboard Belmond's deliciously Deco British Pullman—commandeered today by *Vogue* to celebrate the launch of a new Baz Luhrmann–and Catherine Martin–designed carriage—that he has secretly filmed a Madonna video with Kate Moss and Benedict Cumberbatch, they fall on him as though he were carrion. ("She runs, um, pretty late," chuckles Madekwe in response to the barrage of questions.)

The clutch of productions represented by the group in this story will define the theatrical calendar this autumn. There's Brian Cox (marvelously grumpy in *The Score,* coming to Washington, DC, in September), Letitia Wright (appearing in the newsroom play *The Story* at the National), Mason Alexander Park (angelic-voiced and scene-stealing in Broadway's *Much Ado About Nothing,* in previews from October), Sadie Soverall (a standout in the London production of *John Proctor Is the Villain,* which is getting another West End run early next year), and Josephine Thiesen (who recently played Alice in a staging of *Alice in Wonderland* in Hamburg, and will soon be seen in Tom Ford's next film *Cry to Heaven*).

The shoot is a fashion play: lovers, schemers, ingenues, villains, braggarts, all under the direction of photographer Annie Leibovitz. The actor Luke Thompson, dozing in a brocade chair (and soon to play opposite Keira Knightley in *The Lives of Others* at the Adelphi), takes the temperature best: "With film and TV you're not there when the audience is unwrapping their present. In theater—that charged feeling. It's electric."

He smiles, watching Park take a turn through the carriage in magenta Valentino couture. "You have to really believe in it."—GILES HATTERSLEY

STAGE WHISPERS

FROM LEFT: Sadie Soverall wears a **Miss Sohee** gown. Harriet Walter in **Valentino.** Wright, in an **Erdem** suit, is making her National Theatre debut playing an ambitious journalist in *The Story.* She likens theater to the gym: "You need strength, discipline," she says, "not only in the mind, but in body and spirit."

FLYING COLORS
Soverall, in **Givenchy by Sarah Burton**, is taking her recent starring role in *John Proctor Is the Villain* to its West End revival next year. While she "grew up looking at the tortured artists," she says, "I've learned how to look after myself a lot more."

ALL THAT GLITTERS
Mason Alexander Park, in **Valentino Haute Couture,** is making her Broadway debut in Jamie Lloyd's acclaimed production of *Much Ado About Nothing*. "I grew up not having a very clear-cut path as an artist, especially as a trans artist," she says. "I'm just trying to find more parts written for strange, singular people."

SHALL WE DANCE?
FROM LEFT: Thompson in a **Junya Watanabe Man** jacket. Cox in a **Moss** waistcoat and **Polo Ralph Lauren** trousers. Thiesen in **Chanel.** Wright in **Danielle Frankel.** Archie Madekwe in **Dior.** This year, Thiesen stars in Nobel laureate Elfriede Jelinek's *Prinzessinendramen*—a feminist retelling of fairy tales—and she'll be seen in Tom Ford's upcoming film *Cry to Heaven.* "I have made my own world," she says, "to have the freedom to explore things in our art that don't really exist yet."